possibility of [nuclear] war at the conference table with a calm composure, but later reflections on that possibility in private talks with one or two of us made him distressed'.[97] O'Donnell also recounts that on various occasions (after the Vienna Summit, and during the Berlin and Cuban crises), 'he always said the same thing in the same way: "I keep thinking of the children, not my kids or yours, but the children all over the world."'

Would Kennedy or Khrushchev (or indeed any Soviet, American or British) political leader have accepted the deaths of thousands, or hundreds of thousands, or indeed millions of their citizens without retaliating? Perhaps. Yet, the words of General Turgidson sound chillingly prescient: 'it is necessary now … to choose between two admittedly regrettable – but nevertheless distinguishable post-war environments – one where we lose twenty million people, and the other where we lose a hundred and fifty million people.'[98]

Suppose Washington was destroyed and the President dead? Whether and/ or how to retaliate would have been decided by a senior military commander. Suppose the decision was faced by General Power? It is perhaps worth noting that his former boss, General Curtis LeMay, considered him 'not stable' and 'sadistic'.[99] We cannot say with certainty what Power would have done, though the probability he would launch the SIOP in full was likely akin to the probability of the sun rising in the east and setting in the west.

The context was different for Moscow. Given overwhelming US quantitative and qualitative nuclear superiority, Soviet pre-emption would not have prevented US retaliation. A Soviet attack on the United States would surely have provoked massive retaliation. For Moscow, it would be committing suicide out of fear of death. It is very difficult to see how an attack could serve rational political purposes (though history is strewn with actions that did not serve rational political purposes). What the Presidium understood about rational political purposes in nuclear war is open to speculation. What they understood about US overwhelming quantitative and qualitative nuclear superiority is unclear. The decision to use nuclear weapons would have been taken amidst the most terrifying and confusing of